DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

# What Is the Purpose of Life?

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

**Sefer:** Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 3: the Torah and the misvot, the purpose of life (first paragraph) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 30 May 2022

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## The essence of the whole book

The third essay is titled "On the Torah and the Misvot", but the Rabbi explained that it is really about the purpose of life. Like the first two essays it is revision, "but he puts it beautifully". This is the essence of Derech Hashem.

## Why God created humanity

God created humanity so that people could cleave to Him and so receive His goodness. The Rabbi set out the logic again. Someone who is good wants to give good, and someone who is perfectly good wants to give perfect goodness. But perfect goodness is found only in God Himself. The best gift would be to give of Himself, but He cannot, because, as the first essay taught, God is one; He cannot make you the same as Him. So the next best thing is to allow human beings to connect to Him. "That is the greatest goodness, and that is the purpose of this whole world."

## Why not just plug us in?

How is that connection reached? By becoming better people. A person is given two paths, good and bad, and when he chooses the good of his own free will, he earns eternal goodness.

The Rabbi asked the obvious question: why not simply create endless creatures already attached to God, "just plug us all in"? Because you have to earn it. Something given as a gift cannot compare with something you have worked for. A participant gave the name for this: bread of shame. Someone who is always being handed things does not feel good about it; people want to be independent. So we are placed among opportunities for purity and impurity, good and bad, and by choosing the good we make ourselves better.

## An audience with the Queen

With the Queen's Jubilee the following week, the Rabbi returned to an analogy from two years earlier, and stressed how important it is to pass this on, because people have "a very childish

concept" of Gehinnom and Gan Eden.

Imagine that the greatest gift there is would be to spend time in the Queen's presence. The more you train yourself to be regal, to have table manners, to dress, speak and behave properly, the longer she will be comfortable spending time with you. Turn up without any of that, and after a minute she will say goodbye. "It's exactly the same with God." The better our choices, the better the people we become, and the more we have in common with the source of all goodness.

So the World to Come is not a prize handed out for good deeds or a penalty for bad ones. It is a person living with the consequences of the identity he or she has created. A participant asked whether this denies the principle of reward and punishment. The Rabbi said of course there is reward and punishment, but not the children's version of sweets for good behaviour and fire for bad. If you have spent years learning how to sit at the royal table and so get a weekend with the Queen instead of a garden tea, "I wouldn't call that reward. I would call that consequence." It is like going to the gym: losing weight is not a reward for exercise, it is simply what exercise does.

A participant added that sin brings shame, the "fire" of Gehinnom being embarrassment. The Rabbi agreed that this is part of the same picture. Nor is it a pass mark of 51 per cent. Using his stadium image, everyone basically gets into the stadium, but whether you sit in the box at pitch side or in the back row depends on how much you have worked on yourself.

## Why everything else exists

The Ramhal adds: all other creatures were created only to make the world complete for humanity, so that people can serve God and reach the perfect good. The Rabbi admitted this may be controversial, since it means that animals have no intrinsic value apart from this purpose. A participant suggested the purpose is to create choices, such as whether to eat a non-kosher animal or to treat an animal well; the Rabbi called it a possible theory. Another mentioned that pig organs, so close to human ones, are now used in medicine. The Rabbi said that using a creature for such advances is itself a good choice, elevating the mundane. But the Ramhal himself says he cannot tell us the specific purpose of each creature. What the Rabbis taught is that the world exists for humanity, and humanity exists to attain true goodness.

He warned against building a whole philosophy on one misvah. Saar baalei hayim, not causing animals pain, is very important. But it never outweighs human life. He recalled the outcry a few years ago when an animal in a zoo was killed because a child was in danger. Even if there is only a tiny chance of a human being being harmed, he said, our duty is to protect the person. We must look after animals and protect God's world, but they are always second to people.

## Not a test, a banner

The essay continues: God saw that to reach this goodness we should be put to a nisayon, usually translated "test". The Rabbi said he does not like that translation, because it suggests a God waiting to trip us up. As an example of that dangerous thinking he cited the claim that dinosaur bones were planted to test whether we would still believe the world is 6,000 years old, an argument also found in Christian apologetics.

The root of nisayon is nes. In Parashat Hukkat, Moshe is told to place the copper serpent al nes, on a pole or banner. A miracle is called a nes because it raises God's name high like a banner. So a nisayon is not a trap but an opportunity to be raised up. "It's to raise us. It's to elevate us." The next class would continue with holiness and impurity.

## Summary

- God, the perfect good, gives the greatest good by letting people cleave to Him.
- We must earn that closeness through free choice, because a gift we did not work for cannot compare.
- The World to Come is the consequence of the person we have made ourselves, like time spent with the Queen.
- All other creatures exist for humanity's purpose; caring for animals matters, but never above human life.
- A nisayon is not a test to trip us up but a banner to raise us.

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